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TUMULTUOUS TIMES

While I was starting to play some of the best cricket of my career, at home my life had undergone a fundamental transformation. That is because on 12 October 1997 I had received my greatest ever gift, with Anjali giving birth to our first child. I had shared the news that I was expecting a child with my team-mates when we were touring Zimbabwe in February 1997 and organized an impromptu party in celebration. I was thrilled at the thought of becoming a father.

The night before the moment finally arrived I was with my friend Sunil Harshe on the terrace of Anjali's family's house in Breach Candy. The house was just two minutes away from the hospital and I had been told by Anjali's paediatrician friend, Dr Ajit Gajendragadkar, that he would call me the moment they brought her out of the delivery room. My prolonged presence in the hospital would have caused difficulties for the authorities and it was best that I waited for the call. Restless and anxious, I was lying on the terrace, staring up at the sky, and I remember saying to Sunil that within hours I would be a father and turn a new page in my life. All I was praying for was that Anjali and the child would both be safe and healthy.

When Dr Gajendragadkar finally called me with the good news the following day, I arrived at the hospital within minutes with a video camera in my hand. Seconds after reaching the maternity ward, I saw the doctor carrying my child in his arms and that's when I was told that God had blessed us with a baby girl. I recorded the whole thing and cherish the recording of the doctor bringing my daughter out to me. It's impossible to describe the overwhelming sensation of seeing my child